



From Hobby to Career: Exploring Professional eSports in Bangladesh

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Abstract

The eSports phenomenon, a convergence of gaming and sports, has evolved beyond casual recreation, establishing itself as a burgeoning professional pursuit globally. This transformation is particularly pronounced in Bangladesh, fueled by a youthful demographic and widespread internet access. This research investigates the motivations driving individuals to embrace eSports as a career, scrutinizing associated challenges such as societal perceptions, financial considerations, and broader cultural implications. Through a combination of surveys, expert interviews, and a comprehensive examination of 64 survey responses and in-person interviews with 22 participants, this study reveals that personal enthusiasm serves as a primary driver for players, despite the challenges of balancing academic and personal responsibilities. While skepticism persists, eSports is gaining momentum, fostering communities and innovative employment opportunities. To sustain this positive trajectory, government support and recognition of study limitations are imperative. This study offers a thorough analysis of eSports' profound impact on the socio-cultural landscape and anticipates its future ramifications for Bangladesh. The findings contribute to the HCI and ICT4D communities, offering insights into the intersection of technology, culture, and eSports in a rapidly evolving digital nation.

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1 Introduction

In the dynamic evolution of global gaming, eSports has emerged as a transformative phenomenon, blurring the lines between leisure and competition. Scholars like Sebastian Block and Florian Haack

[4] have explored this shift, capturing the essence of the global gaming narrative. Within Bangladesh, a nation embracing digitalization, eSports is undergoing a notable transformation from a casual hobby to a serious pursuit. Drawing insights from eSports matrices [6] and diverse definitions [8], this paper seeks to unravel the factors driving eSports' popularity locally, assess its economic viability, and understand its perception as a viable career choice. By examining motivations globally through the lens of Guo Freeman and Donghee Yvette Wohn [8] and Juho Hamari and Max Sjöblom [10], we bridge the global-local gap, shedding light on the emerging role of eSports as an economic driver in regions like Bangladesh due to its integration with digital platforms and community engagement.

eSports reflects the evolving societal perceptions of digital careers, showcasing how increased access to internet connectivity has transformed gaming into a viable career option for the youth [10]. This transformation highlights a growing acceptance of non-traditional career paths, driven by the potential for financial independence, technological engagement, and social recognition [25]. As a result, eSports is emerging as both a cultural and economic force, offering new opportunities for aspiring gamers in Bangladesh and similar regions.

1.1 The Evolution of Gaming: A Lens on the Past and Present

Globally, the trajectory of gaming has undergone a profound evolution, transitioning from a simple recreational activity to a sophisticated and competitive pursuit known as eSports. Scholars such as Sebastian Block and Florian Haack [4] have extensively studied this global shift, elucidating the multifaceted dimensions of the burgeoning eSports industry. The narrative extends beyond entertainment, intertwining technology, skill, and community engagement worldwide. The rapid growth of digital infrastructure, particularly in emerging economies like Bangladesh, has enabled eSports to gain momentum as both a leisure activity shown in figure 1 and a professional pursuit shown in figure 2, highlighting the potential for financial stability and career development within this industry [34].

In Bangladesh, the evolution of gaming mirrors the global trend but also carries distinct local nuances. As internet access and affordable gaming equipment become more widespread, the local eSports community in Bangladesh is increasingly professionalizing, providing pathways for aspiring players to turn their hobby into a viable



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career[5]. As the gaming landscape transforms from casual leisure to a more structured and competitive endeavor, Bangladesh's eSports scene emerges as an integral part of this evolution, reflecting the country's unique cultural and technological context[3]. Exploring this evolution provides a comprehensive perspective on the past and present of gaming, encompassing both the global and local dynamics that shape the eSports phenomenon.

1.2 The Narrative of Competitive Gaming

Internationally, the narrative of competitive gaming, or eSports, unfolds as a compelling story that transcends conventional perceptions of gaming. Scholars like Guo Freeman and Donghee Yvette Wohn [8] delve into diverse perspectives, enriching our understanding of how eSports is defined and conceptualized. This global narrative is characterized by the fusion of technology, strategic skill, and a vibrant community that elevates gaming into a competitive and spectator sport. In Bangladesh, eSports is now seen as more than just a recreational activity. The rise of local competitions, increased media coverage, and sponsorship opportunities have solidified its perception as a legitimate career path, influenced both by global trends and local participation[11].

Once considered a form of entertainment, eSports has evolved into a serious and structured pursuit, mirroring the global narrative [12]. This evolution is visible in the increasing recognition of professional eSports players and teams, who are becoming household names among the younger generation in Bangladesh[33]. As competitive gaming gains prominence locally, it intertwines with Bangladesh's gaming community, weaving a distinctive storyline reflective of the country's cultural ethos and technological landscape [2, 11]. Examining the narrative of competitive gaming provides insights into how global trends influence local dynamics, shaping the eSports landscape in universal and region-specific ways.

1.3 Unveiling eSports in Bangladesh

In the context of Bangladesh, the emergence of eSports signifies a transformative paradigm within the nation's gaming ecosystem [34]. As digital technologies increasingly integrate into everyday life, eSports has transcended its status as a mere pastime, unveiling itself as a serious and structured pursuit [7]. This growth is driven by the expansion of gaming cafes, community-driven tournaments, and the affordability of gaming hardware, providing new avenues for grassroots players to participate and compete at higher levels [9].

This unveiling reflects both the technological advancements and the evolving preferences of Bangladesh's youth, who see eSports as a viable career opportunity. The rise of local gaming communities and tournaments also fosters social engagement, where players not only compete but also form strong networks, learning from global eSports trends while embracing their cultural identity[39]. Unraveling the layers of eSports in Bangladesh involves exploring how this phenomenon has grown beyond entertainment to become a dynamic force, influencing the gaming landscape and shaping new narratives of competition, community, and career aspirations in the digital age.

1.4 Research Objectives

In recent years, the exponential rise in the popularity of eSports within Bangladesh has captivated an expanding audience, fueled by the pervasive influence of social media, increased internet accessibility, and the availability of affordable gaming equipment [37]. This surge has drawn many, particularly youth, to engage with eSports, either as casual gamers or fervent spectators of competitive events. Local competitions, organized by communities and gaming cafes, have seen substantial participation growth, with grassroots players becoming increasingly involved. Meanwhile, international competitions featuring popular games such as Dota 2, PUBG Mobile, and Free Fire continue to attract significant attention from Bangladeshi audiences [15]. This paper dissects the factors contributing to this remarkable surge in eSports popularity within the Bangladeshi gaming community, shedding light on the dynamics driving this cultural and technological phenomenon.

The financial ecosystem for players and teams in Bangladesh's eSports industry is diverse. Funding primarily comes from sponsors, gaming companies, and occasionally, government organizations. Recognizing the marketing potential, local brands also contribute, leading to larger-scale competitions [9]. For players, income varies based on success and popularity. International professionals earn from tournaments, sponsorships, and ad-supported streaming, while most local players receive modest income from smaller events and donations. This paper explores the factors shaping income dynamics in Bangladesh's eSports, shedding light on the financial sustainability across different levels of the gaming community.

The perspective on eSports as a career option in Bangladesh has shifted significantly. Once viewed as a mere hobby, eSports is now recognized as a competitive and potentially lucrative industry[35]. This transformation is largely driven by its increasing national and international popularity, where professional success and financial security have become attainable goals for players. Family support, traditionally a key factor in career decisions, has also evolved. While parents were initially hesitant about gaming careers, the growing respect and recognition of eSports have led families to consider it a viable career path for their children. The industry's increasing acceptance is further supported by regional eSports organizations, successful players, and official recognition from national sports authorities. This paper delves into the factors shaping eSports as a career choice in Bangladesh, offering insights into the industry's evolving dynamics within the local context.

In this investigation, we seek answers to the following research questions:

- **RQ1:** What factors contribute to the growing popularity of eSports within the gaming community in Bangladesh?
- **RQ2:** How is eSports perceived as a career choice in the context of Bangladesh?

1.5 Our Contribution

Our research presents a comprehensive exploration of the eSports landscape in Bangladesh, contributing significant insights into its evolution, economic dynamics, and the changing perception of eSports as a viable career choice. By synthesizing global and local perspectives, we bridge the gap between universal trends and the unique cultural and technological context of Bangladesh, unraveling



Figure 1: Aspiring eSports player

the layers of eSports from a casual pastime to a structured and competitive pursuit. Moreover, our analysis highlights the role of local sponsorships, varying income sources for players, and regional tournament infrastructures in shaping the sustainability and growth of eSports in Bangladesh [9]. These factors illustrate how economic opportunities differ at various levels of competition, influencing player retention and the potential for career longevity.

This research holds particular relevance for the gaming community and organizations, offering nuanced understandings for designing user-centric eSports platforms and addressing the socio-economic aspects of gaming in emerging markets. By delving into the local dynamics of eSports, our work enriches the understanding of the unique challenges and opportunities within Bangladesh’s rapidly evolving eSports ecosystem, particularly in terms of professional growth, community building, and financial stability.

2 Literature review

The literature review navigates the diverse realms of the eSports industry, exploring its economic landscape, viewer motivations, and identity dynamics within the gaming community. From foundational works like Wagner (2006) advocating for eSports as a distinct research area to recent studies dissecting industry trajectories and intersections with traditional sports and media, the review provides a concise overview of the multifaceted dimensions that shape the intricate world of eSports.

2.1 Understanding eSports

Reitman et al. advocate for a comprehensive understanding of eSports beyond traditional gameplay analysis [28]. His paper emphasizes the influence of contextual factors on player behavior, stressing the need for interdisciplinary collaboration and improved accessibility in the eSports domain. Addressing the challenges of defining eSports, Cranmer et al. introduce the eSports Matrix—a conceptual framework categorizing eSports into four realms [6]. They call for a unified approach, identifying key considerations and outlining promising research directions while underscoring the industry’s rapid growth. Providing a global perspective, Jenny et al. scrutinize eSports competitions across the US, Europe, and Asia, emphasizing the importance of flexible facilities and leveraging open systems theory to elucidate tournament dynamics [12]. Saiz et al.



Figure 2: Professional eSports player

focus on the global rise of eSports, explicitly examining the Spanish field. Using a SWOT analysis, they identify key drivers, emphasizing the link between knowledge management and sustainability [30]. Beyond economic impacts, the study explores societal ramifications, advocating for inclusive decision-making. Post-COVID-19, the authors predict industry growth and recommend regulatory measures based on comprehensive insights from industry interviews. This collective research contributes to a nuanced understanding of eSports, transcending geographical boundaries and highlighting the industry’s evolving landscape.

2.2 Growth of eSports

Nagorsky et al. address a crucial gap in eSports research by proposing a performance model grounded in game research and sports science [22]. Through surveying 1,835 eSports participants, the study reveals distinctive competence profiles and training patterns across genres. The emphasis on the transfer effects of gaming skills underscores the research’s call for an integrated approach to eSports training, providing valuable insights for future methodologies and highlighting the need to tailor training to specific eSports disciplines. Macey et al. explore the symbiotic relationship between eSports spectating and video game consumption intentions in a related paper [19]. Utilizing structural equation modeling, their study establishes strong connections between eSports spectators’ motivations and intentions to watch, participate, and make in-game purchases. Notably, the findings position eSports as a potent marketing channel, particularly in “Free-to-Play” models, offering crucial insights into the dynamic interplay between eSports and video game consumption dynamics. Shifting the focus to the growth of eSports, Jenny et al. contribute by delving into its classification in higher education [13]. They advocate for formal recognition as a scholarship-awarding intercollegiate athletic sport, providing a historical overview and defining eSports while contrasting it with conventional sports concepts. The paper aims to spark a debate on eSports’s increasing prevalence and significance in competitive domains worldwide. Additionally, Pluss et al. advocate studying eSports expertise as a unique avenue for understanding human achievement potential [26]. In the realm of competitive video gaming, eSports offers objective monitoring of developmental activities and the emergence of expertise in unguided environments. The

paper positions eSports research as an opportunity to advance the comprehension and evaluation of human expertise, presenting novel insights into the realm of achievement potential.

2.3 Audience in eSports

Scholz et al. provide a comprehensive introductory overview of the eSports industry within the context of media management [32]. They delineate industry characteristics, stakeholders, and governing principles, highlighting the potential contributions of studying eSports to understanding digitized media management and sustainable business models. Despite acknowledging complexities and risks, the authors predict a continued expansion of the eSports industry, drawing parallels with traditional media's successful adaptation to digitization. In a related vein, Xiao et al. employ the Theory of Reasoned Action (TRA) to investigate variables associated with the intent to observe eSports [38]. Utilizing structural equation modeling, their study uncovers the positive influence of behavioral beliefs and subjective norms on attitudes toward eSports viewing, ultimately impacting the intention to observe. This research provides essential insights into the psychology of eSports viewers, offering valuable guidance for sports marketing professionals in product and service development. Additionally, Rosell et al. contribute to understanding eSports audiences by exploring the classification of eSports as a legitimate form of sports practice [29]. Recognizing its recent growth, the authors advocate for a closer examination of its sporting characteristics, using "League of Legends" as an example of global success. The article anticipates potential challenges and policy implications in the evolving sports field. Shifting the focus to motivational factors, Lee et al. investigate influences on time spent on eSports gaming versus traditional sports engagement [17]. Analyzing 515 college students, the study identifies competition and skill as significant drivers, with peer pressure having a minor impact. The research suggests tailored marketing messages targeting these motivations for strategic goals. This collective body of work contributes significantly to understanding various aspects of the eSports industry, from its management dynamics to audience behavior and motivational factors influencing player engagement.

2.4 eSports Industry and Economic Factors

The eSports industry's multifaceted dimensions and economic factors have been explored through various lenses. Newman et al., for instance, employ narrative economics to dissect private investment growth in North American eSports teams, revealing how public narratives align with epidemic models and impact economic behaviors [23]. Hamari et al. conducted a comprehensive study on eSports viewership, uncovering motivations such as escapism and the allure of novelty and positioning eSports as a significant manifestation of modern sports and digital interaction [10]. Wagner sheds light on eSports's potential to influence diverse research areas, emphasizing its underexplored nature in academia and advocating for a paradigm shift. In a similar vein, Xue et al. delve into the impact of eSports on identities within the gaming community, revealing narratives' role in constructing community boundaries [28].

In the examination of the eSports industry's trajectory, Block et al. extensively define eSports and trace its financial evolution, contributing to a deeper understanding of its economic landscape [4].

Jenny et al. focus on the global phenomenon of eSports, analyzing spectator trends and emphasizing the need for flexible facilities in hosting events [12]. Marques discusses the global appeal of sports and the explosive growth of eSports, tapping into the human inclination for competition. Johnson et al. comprehensively analyze the roles of various stakeholders, highlighting financial gains and new career prospects [14]. Olsen et al. pragmatically focus on the growth of the eSports industry, identifying key factors and predicting substantial growth [24]. Freeman et al. conducted an inaugural investigation into eSports, enriching understanding through qualitative analysis of player interviews [8]. Mangelaja et al. provide a comprehensive economic analysis, introducing novel measurement methods and comparing demand dynamics with traditional sports markets [20].

Additionally, Kriglstein et al. discuss the convergence of streaming technology and eSports, emphasizing the spectator experience [16]. Lohman et al. address eSports as a commercial activity, proposing strategies for development in Ukraine [18]. Pu et al. investigate using video games, particularly eSports, for content production and fan engagement during the COVID-19 pandemic, emphasizing gamification as a unique and complementary product [27]. Collectively, this research illuminates the intricate landscape of the eSports industry, spanning economic growth, viewer motivations, identity dynamics, and the evolving intersection of eSports with traditional sports and media.

2.5 Research Gap

The current eSports literature provides valuable insights, yet significant research gaps persist. Global perspectives dominate, neglecting the regional nuances of eSports, particularly in countries like Bangladesh. Moreover, comprehensive examinations of eSports in digitally advancing nations are scarce, leaving a void we aim to fill by exploring the intersection of culture and technology in the Bangladeshi eSports landscape. While global economic aspects of eSports are well explored, a gap exists in understanding local economic viability, particularly in Bangladesh. Our research delves into the financial dynamics at the local level, offering insights into the economic sustainability of players, teams, and the industry. Lastly, the perception of eSports as a career choice is recognized globally, but understanding it within specific cultural contexts, like Bangladesh, remains limited. Investigating the factors influencing the local view of eSports as a viable career option provides nuanced insights for regional development. Our interdisciplinary approach seeks to address these gaps, contributing a localized perspective on eSports in Bangladesh and fostering a more holistic understanding of its cultural, economic, and social dimensions in the context of a rapidly evolving digital nation.

3 Methodology

This research investigates the emerging field of professional eSports in Bangladesh through a mixed-methods approach. The methodology integrates both quantitative and qualitative data collection techniques, aimed at exploring participants' experiences and perceptions. Snowball sampling was utilized as a practical approach for recruiting participants within the close-knit eSports community in Bangladesh. To gather diverse perspectives from various roles

Demographic Factor	Category	Count	Percentage
Gender	Male	79	91.86%
	Female	7	8.14%
Age	Below 18	6	6.98%
	18-24	54	62.79%
	25-30	23	26.74%
	31-35	3	3.49%
Occupation	Business Person	5	5.81%
	Employee	19	22.09%
	Student	58	67.44%
	eSports Player	4	4.65%

Table 1: Summary Data of participants

within the eSports ecosystem, we employed quantitative surveys alongside qualitative interviews. The progression of key research elements is illustrated in Figure 3

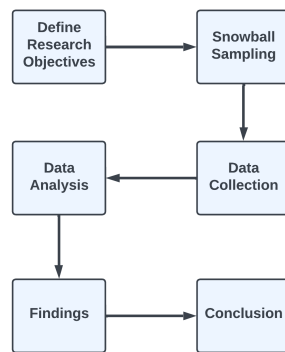


Figure 3: Workflow of our research methodology.

3.1 Participant Recruitment

We engaged 86 individuals actively involved in Bangladesh’s eSports community, selecting them using the snowball sampling technique. We chose this method due to the relatively small and close-knit nature of the eSports community in Bangladesh. Snowball sampling allowed us to reach individuals deeply embedded in the community, including casual players, professionals, and organizers. We ensured diversity in our participant pool by considering factors such as age, gender, and geographic location. Participants represented various roles within the eSports ecosystem and varied in their involvement, from casual gamers to dedicated professionals.

3.2 Demographics

The sample consisted of participants from diverse backgrounds, predominantly young adults aged 18–24 (62.79%) and 25–30 (26.74%), which aligns with global trends in the eSports sector. A gender imbalance was noted, with 91.86% of participants identifying as male, reflecting broader patterns of male dominance in the eSports industry. This gender disparity underscores the need for future research to explore the experiences of underrepresented groups in

eSports. Educationally, 72.09% of participants were undergraduate students, and 26.74% were graduate students.

3.3 Survey Data Collection

For the quantitative aspect of this research, we administered a structured Google Forms survey to 64 participants. The survey aimed to explore participants’ motivations for engaging in eSports, their perceptions of competition, and the influence of technology on their involvement. It included questions about favorite eSports genres, gaming frequency and duration, and preferred platforms for accessing content.

Key survey questions included inquiries about favorite eSports genres, gaming session frequency and duration, and preferred platforms for accessing eSports content. Additionally, the survey explored participants’ perceptions of the competitive field within eSports, focusing on the significance of teamwork, skill development, and the influence of technological advancements on gameplay experiences. Many of these questions utilized Likert scale options, allowing participants to rate factors such as the importance of teamwork, skill development, and technology in enhancing their gaming experiences. The data collected provided valuable quantitative insights that complemented the qualitative narratives obtained through in-person interviews.

3.4 Interview Data Collection

Our research methodology integrates both in-person and online interviews to gather in-depth insights into the eSports community in Bangladesh. In-person interviews were conducted in various physical settings, including eSports LAN events, tournaments, and participants’ homes. Conducting interviews in participants’ homes provided a personalized and comfortable environment for them to openly share their experiences, motivations, challenges, and aspirations within the eSports field. Additionally, LAN events and tournaments were selected as interview locations to capture the vibrant atmosphere, camaraderie, and competitive spirit present in these gatherings. This approach reflects participant observation and ethnographic research, allowing us to immerse ourselves in the community and observe interactions and dynamics firsthand.

For the online component, we conducted semi-structured interviews through platforms such as Discord, Facebook Groups, Messenger, and audio calls. This allowed us to reach participants who were not available for in-person meetings while still ensuring a detailed exploration of their personal experiences, challenges, and pivotal moments in their eSports journeys. These online interviews offered a flexible and convenient way for participants to share their perspectives, focusing on the evolution of their interests and the dynamics within the eSports community.

By combining in-person interviews, online platforms, and participant observation as part of our ethnographic approach, we were able to capture both the emotional and social dimensions of eSports involvement. This methodology provided a holistic understanding of the community, uncovering significant stories, personal anecdotes, and experiential knowledge from a diverse range of eSports enthusiasts.

3.5 Data Analysis

In our comprehensive study, we strategically employ a dual-method approach, meticulously examining both qualitative and quantitative datasets to uncover profound insights into the dynamic eSports landscape in Bangladesh. Transitioning to the quantitative aspect, we analyze data collected from a survey of 64 respondents using robust statistical techniques. This quantitative approach, involving measures such as frequency distributions, percentages, and correlation analyses, plays a pivotal role in identifying overarching trends, patterns, and measurable aspects within the eSports community. A consistent theme among survey respondents is the increasing significance of eSports involvement in their lives.

Focusing on the qualitative segment, our in-depth exploration comprises 22 in-person interviews, utilizing a rigorous thematic analysis approach. The qualitative dataset includes 174 quotes and notes, showcasing the richness of participant narratives. The first and second authors actively engaged in coding and documenting the data, identifying 27 recurring sub-themes through the thematic analysis process. These sub-themes, such as "Economic Dynamics," "Career Choice," "Passion, Challenges," "Societal Acceptance," "Financial Aspects," "Future Prospects," "Impact on Personal Life," and "Supportive Ecosystem," encapsulate the diverse and nuanced dimensions that define the eSports community. To reduce intercoder bias, we employed Cohen's Kappa method, achieving a result of 82%, which reflects a high level of agreement between coders and strengthens the reliability of our qualitative findings[36].

3.6 Ethical Concerns

This research is guided by a robust ethical framework that prioritizes the well-being and rights of the 86 participants. Informed consent, detailing the study's purpose, is diligently obtained from each participant. Strict confidentiality measures are observed, safeguarding participants' identities. Data is securely stored and accessible only to the research team to preserve privacy. Participants are assured of aggregated and anonymized responses, upholding individual privacy while contributing to the broader narrative. The study aligns with ethical guidelines, emphasizing transparency, respect for autonomy, and responsible data handling. Ethical approval from the university's Institutional Review Board underscores our commitment to ethical conduct, enhancing the research's integrity [31] and validity while fostering trust with the eSports community in Bangladesh.

4 Findings

This research paper provides an in-depth examination of the data collected from individuals actively engaged in the professional eSports industry in Bangladesh. The analysis highlights several key insights that shed light on the development, challenges, and future potential of eSports as a professional career option in the country. These findings contribute to the existing knowledge in the field while presenting opportunities for future research within relevant communities, including ICTD and HCI, where applicable.

4.1 Passion and Inspiration: Fueling a Non-Traditional Choice

This section delves into the significant role of passion in propelling individuals towards a professional career in eSports in Bangladesh. The findings from the survey reveal that a substantial 68.3% of respondents identified a passion for gaming as their primary driving force. In comparison, 22.2% were motivated by prospects for financial gain, and 9.5% sought fame and recognition. Participant 1 articulated the transformative power of passion, stating,

"Gaming was my childhood passion, and it grew into a commitment to excel in eSports. It's what drove me to pursue this unconventional career path."- P1

Participant 6 echoed a similar sentiment:

"Growing up, I always deeply loved video games. As I saw the rise of eSports globally, I was inspired by the idea of turning my passion into a profession."- P6

This sentiment was recurrent among participants P2, P3, P9, P11, and P16, who expressed analogous mindsets. These testimonials highlight the profound impact of childhood interests in gaming evolving into unwavering commitments to excel in the competitive realm of eSports. As underscored by 68.3% of participants, the passion for gaming emerged as a potent force that transcended societal norms and doubts, motivating them to diverge from conventional career paths and embark on a professional journey in eSports. Only 22.2% cited financial gain as an additional motivator for their career choice.

In summary, the convergence of narratives from participants P1 and P6, along with the shared mindset of others, underscores the transformative power of passion in shaping the non-traditional career choices within the eSports industry in Bangladesh. This thematic consistency across participants further solidifies the significance of passion as a driving force, contributing to a nuanced understanding of the motivational dynamics prevalent among professional eSports enthusiasts nationwide.

4.2 Challenges and Achievements: Triumphs Amidst Trials

This section delves into the narratives provided by participants, shedding light on the contrasting experiences of challenges faced and triumphs achieved within the eSports industry in Bangladesh. The accounts reveal a delicate balance between significant accomplishments, such as victories in competitive events and high rankings, and persistent obstacles that significantly influence the trajectory of individuals within the eSports field.

Participant 3 shed light on a common technical challenge:

"Connectivity issues during tournaments have been a challenge. It's something the community is actively working to address."- P3

The acknowledgment of connectivity issues underscores the practical challenges faced by eSports professionals, highlighting the need for collective efforts within the community to overcome these technical hindrances. Participant 4 expressed the pervasive nature of Internet issues, noting,

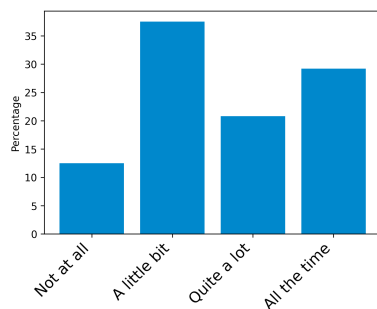


Figure 4: Survey response of “Have any of your family or friends advised you against pursuing gaming professionally?”

“Internet issues are a nightmare. And convincing people that gaming is a legit career is an ongoing battle.”- P4

Through our interviews, participants highlighted governmental challenges as a major barrier to the growth of the eSports industry. Many noted that the Bangladesh government does not fully understand or support the sector. For instance, they frequently referenced the banning of popular games, such as the ban on PUBG on August 16, 2023, which limits access to globally recognized games and hinders the professional development of players[3].

This sentiment resonates with the broader struggle to legitimize gaming as a viable career option and emphasizes the tangible obstacles presented by technological shortcomings. Participants 9 and 13 echoed similar sentiments, further emphasizing the widespread nature of these challenges within the eSports community.

Participants also shared that cultural perceptions of gaming as a non-productive activity still prevail, making it difficult for them to convince skeptics that eSports is a legitimate career path. They described the challenge of juggling intensive training, education, and personal relationships, which further complicates their professional lives. However, many reflected on their significant achievements, including victories in competitions and high rankings against tough opponents. These successes were viewed as essential in strengthening their self-confidence and dedication to their careers.

In summary, the juxtaposition of achievements and challenges within the eSports landscape in Bangladesh underscores the multifaceted nature of the industry. Technical hurdles, governmental regulations, cultural perceptions, and financial difficulties represent obstacles that demand collective solutions, while victories and high rankings serve as a testament to the resilience and commitment of eSports professionals. This nuanced understanding contributes to a comprehensive exploration of the trials and triumphs shaping the professional journey within the eSports domain in Bangladesh.

4.3 Societal Acceptance and Growth Potential: Navigating Perception and Reality

This section delves into the evolving landscape of societal acceptance and the growth potential of eSports in Bangladesh, drawing insights from both survey data and participant interviews. The findings illuminate the changing perspectives surrounding eSports in the nation and its potential for expansion. According to our

survey data, 96.7% of respondents expressed optimism about the growth potential of eSports (Yes: 58; No: 2). Interviews with participants further reinforced this positive outlook, with 95.5% affirming the growth potential (Yes: 21; No: 1). These figures underscore a prevailing belief in the promising future of eSports in Bangladesh. Participant 09 encapsulates the evolving narrative of societal acceptance, stating,

“It’s gradually gaining acceptance. Initially, there were skeptics, but as eSports gains more visibility, people are starting to appreciate it as a legitimate profession.”- P9

This sentiment reflects a gradual shift in perception, highlighting the increasing acknowledgment of eSports as a valid and respectable career path. Participant 54 echoes this sentiment, noting,

“More people are seeing eSports as a real job because it takes skill and can make money. But some old-fashioned thinkers still aren’t sure about it.”- P54

These perspectives underscore the ongoing struggle to dispel traditional notions and emphasize the skill and financial potential inherent in eSports. Participant 60 provides a forward-looking perspective, stating,

“No people don’t support eSports as a valid job yet, but after a few years, people will accept it. For example, a few years ago, YouTube for a living was taboo, but now it has become accepted, so why not eSports? It has the potential.”- P60

This viewpoint reflects a historical parallel with accepting unconventional career paths, emphasizing the potential for a transformative shift in societal attitudes toward eSports in the coming years. Despite the optimism, challenges persist, particularly from older generations. As Participant 54 points out,

“Some old-fashioned thinkers still aren’t sure about it.”- P54

Participants emphasized that eSports stands out from many other fields in its lack of gender bias, offering equal opportunities for people of all genders to participate. This inclusivity was often highlighted as a key factor in the potential growth of the industry in Bangladesh.

In addition to the inclusivity of eSports, participants pointed out that educational institutions also play a significant role in the industry’s growth. Many universities in Bangladesh organize LAN tournaments, providing platforms for players to showcase their skills while promoting eSports as a legitimate career path. These events not only help players develop competitive gaming abilities but also allow them to gain visibility within the broader eSports community. Furthermore, corporate sponsorship is playing an increasingly important role in supporting the growth of eSports in Bangladesh. Many companies sponsor these university-hosted tournaments and other events, acknowledging the potential of eSports as a growing industry. This corporate backing not only offers financial support but also helps legitimize eSports as a serious professional option in the country.

This acknowledgment highlights the need to continue educating and changing perceptions surrounding eSports as a legitimate profession. In conclusion, the amalgamation of survey data and

participant testimonials paints a complex picture of societal acceptance and the growth potential of eSports in Bangladesh. The positive outlook, coupled with the acknowledgment of ongoing challenges, contributes to a nuanced understanding of the evolving dynamics within the eSports landscape and its trajectory in the national cultural and professional spheres.

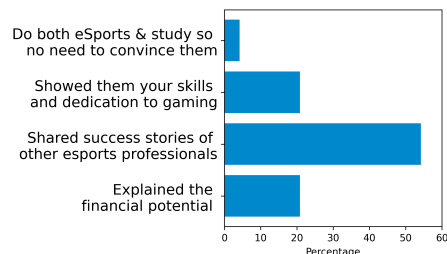


Figure 5: Survey response of “How did you persuade your family members that an eSports profession was viable?”

4.4 Financial Aspects and Future Prospects: A Path to Sustainability

This section meticulously explores eSports’s financial aspects and future prospects in Bangladesh, drawing insights from survey data and participant perspectives. The findings shed light on the industry’s economic dimensions and eSports’s perceived longevity as a career choice. According to our survey data shown in Figure 6, the financial landscape within the professional eSports field exhibits significant variation. Most participants, 58.7 percent, reported earnings less than BDT 20,000 (USD 185), followed by 27 percent between BDT 20,000 (USD 185) and BDT 50,000 (USD 460), 7.9 percent between BDT 50,000 (USD 460) and BDT 1,00,000 (USD 920), and 6.3 percent earning more than BDT 1,00,000 (USD 920). These diverse income brackets underscore the economic diversity within the eSports profession in Bangladesh.

Survey results affirm the overwhelmingly positive outlook regarding the future prospects of eSports as a long-term career choice. A mere 9.1% of participants perceived eSports as a temporary trend, while an overwhelming 90.9% believed in its enduring nature. The resounding majority rejecting the notion of eSports as a fleeting trend signifies a collective confidence in its sustained relevance. Participant 15 encapsulates this sentiment, emphasizing,

“Long-term career opportunity, for sure. It’s not a trend; it’s a revolution.”- P15

Participant 22 echoes this conviction:

“eSports in Bangladesh is here to stay. It’s not a fleeting trend.”- P22

These perspectives resonate with the broader sentiment among participants, indicating a shared belief in eSports’s long-term viability and transformative potential in Bangladesh. Most participants echo these sentiments, expressing confidence in the longevity of eSports as a professional field. These shared mindsets contribute to a robust consensus among professionals, affirming the industry’s permanence and potential for sustained growth.

While eSports holds promise as a long-term career, the financial diversity reported by participants reveals the challenges in achieving financial stability. Participant 63 highlighted a key challenge, stating,

“As digital banking is not widely available, it sometimes becomes a hassle to withdraw funds.”- P63

Participants also emphasized the need for a structured financial ecosystem to ensure the sustainability of eSports as a profession. They highlighted that better access to financial resources and opportunities would allow players to transition from part-time to full-time careers in the industry. Without such support, many felt that the long-term growth and professionalization of eSports in Bangladesh would remain uncertain.

In summary, the financial aspects and future prospects of eSports in Bangladesh are intricately interwoven. The economic diversity among professionals reflects the evolving nature of the industry. At the same time, the overwhelmingly positive outlook on its future longevity underscores a collective belief in the transformative power and enduring relevance of eSports as a viable and sustainable career path in the nation.

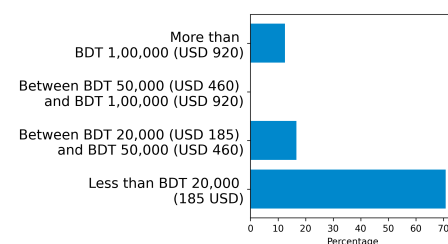


Figure 6: Survey response of “On average, how much does an eSports player in Bangladesh earn per month”

4.5 Impact on Personal Life: Balancing Act and Lifestyle Changes

This segment delves into the narratives shared by participants, offering insights into the intricate interplay between professional eSports pursuits and personal life. The accounts shed light on the challenges and positive transformations experienced by individuals as they strive to strike a harmonious balance. Participants not only embrace the competitive nature of eSports but also emphasize the importance of discipline and structured schedules. Participant 10 shares,

“I have a fixed schedule for gaming. My family, friends, and everyone is aware that I allocated this time for gaming. So, whatever the cause, they communicate with me outside my gaming hours.”- P10

This approach reflects a deliberate effort to establish boundaries and ensure effective communication, underscoring the significance of transparent communication within personal relationships. Participant 26 highlights the critical role of time management, stating,

“Time management is key. I allocate specific hours for practice, studies, and personal time. It’s challenging, but a well-balanced approach is crucial.”- P26

This recognition of the difficulties in managing eSports alongside other commitments emphasizes the need for a strategic, well-rounded approach to time management. These testimonials collectively portray a conscientious effort among eSports professionals to integrate their passion for gaming with a structured lifestyle. The deliberate allocation of time, communication strategies, and a commitment to maintaining balance showcase the resilience and adaptability of individuals navigating the demands of a professional eSports career. Despite the positive outcomes, challenges persist, particularly in reconciling the competing demands of eSports with academic pursuits and interpersonal connections. Participants' experiences in overcoming challenges such as gaming addiction, building discipline, and managing time highlight the broader personal development impacts that emerge from engaging in eSports. These shared experiences underscore the multifaceted influence that professional gaming has on individual growth, particularly in the areas of discipline and time management.

In conclusion, the narratives from participants provide a nuanced understanding of the delicate equilibrium between professional eSports endeavors and personal life. The accounts highlight the positive outcomes, challenges faced, and the transformative impact of structured approaches to time management, contributing to a comprehensive exploration of the intricate dynamics shaping the lives of eSports professionals in Bangladesh.

4.6 Necessities for Growth: Building a Supportive Ecosystem

This section critically examines the prerequisites essential for fostering the growth of eSports in Bangladesh, drawing insights from participant perspectives and survey responses. The findings shed light on the pivotal components necessary to create a thriving and supportive ecosystem for eSports professionals in the country. Participant 41 articulates a comprehensive vision for growth, stating,

"To support the growth of eSports in Bangladesh, key improvements include infrastructure development, government recognition, education, financial support, local tournaments, community building, and international exposure. These changes can help create a more supportive ecosystem for eSports in the country."- P41

This viewpoint highlights the interconnected nature of the various elements needed for sustainable growth in the eSports industry. Participant 76 echoes these sentiments, emphasizing the need for fundamental support, stating,

"We need government support, specialized facilities, and grassroots competitions to grow eSports in Bangladesh."- P76

This participant underscores the importance of foundational pillars, such as government backing and specialized infrastructure, to lay the groundwork for the industry's expansion. A recurring theme in participant feedback is the need for increased financial support from sponsors, which is seen as essential for turning eSports into a viable and sustainable career option. Additionally, many participants expressed the importance of receiving support from family and friends, highlighting how personal networks play a critical role in encouraging individuals to pursue and thrive in eSports careers.

In summary, the identified necessities for the growth of eSports in Bangladesh span a spectrum of requirements, including infrastructure development, government recognition, educational initiatives, financial support, local tournaments, community building, and international exposure. The participants' collective vision underscores the multifaceted nature of building a supportive ecosystem for eSports. The calls for government involvement, specialized facilities, financial support, and familial understanding contribute to a nuanced understanding of the collaborative efforts required to cultivate a flourishing eSports landscape in Bangladesh.

4.7 Youth Culture and Social Dynamics: Shaping the Next Generation

This section delves into the transformative impact of eSports on youth culture and social dynamics in Bangladesh, incorporating participant perspectives to unveil the evolving narrative surrounding this cultural phenomenon. Participant 47 encapsulates the sentiment, declaring,

"It's a cultural revolution. eSports isn't just a hobby; it's a lifestyle defining a new generation."- P47

This profound perspective emphasizes the paradigm shift brought about by eSports, transcending traditional notions of gaming as a mere pastime and instead positioning it as a defining element of contemporary youth culture. The resonance of this sentiment among participants underscores the pervasive influence of eSports in shaping the cultural landscape of the nation. A prevailing theme among participants is the positive outlook toward this cultural transformation. Many participants express a shared belief in the positive impact of eSports on youth, reinforcing the idea that it goes beyond a leisure activity and becomes an integral part of the lifestyle of the new generation. This shift is not merely limited to individual pursuits but extends to fostering social interaction and camaraderie. eSports has emerged as a platform for collective experiences, providing a space for like-minded individuals to connect and form communities. This communal aspect contributes to the creation of a vibrant and supportive network within the eSports community.

In summary, the narratives from participants underscore the transformative nature of eSports, not just as a hobby but as a cultural revolution shaping the ethos of the new generation. The positive outlook and shared belief in the societal benefits of eSports contribute to a deeper understanding of its profound influence on youth culture and social dynamics in Bangladesh.

5 Discussion

In this section, we address the core research questions that have guided our exploration of the eSports landscape in Bangladesh. Firstly, we investigate the factors driving the growing popularity of eSports within the Bangladeshi gaming community, examining how social, technological, and cultural elements interplay. The increasing digitalization and access to affordable technology have facilitated the growth of eSports, highlighting the non-instrumental use of technology as a form of digital leisure. This has allowed a broader demographic to engage with eSports, reshaping gaming from a casual activity into a highly organized pursuit.

Human behavioral theory provides insight into the hesitation many have in pursuing eSports careers[21]. Many individuals prefer traditional jobs, driven by the desire for security and the aversion to taking risks in new, unproven fields. This preference for conventional careers can be attributed to the lack of long-term security perceived in eSports, especially given its developing nature in Bangladesh.

Secondly, we assess the economic viability of eSports in Bangladesh, dissecting the financial ecosystem that supports players and teams. The emerging financial structures, including sponsorships and local tournaments, point to the potential for long-term sustainability, though challenges remain in terms of income stability for grassroots players. However, it is important to note that only those who truly believe in the potential of eSports pursue it professionally, despite the risks. The growing involvement of local brands and companies signals increasing opportunities for professionalization within the industry.

The study also reveals that the Bangladeshi government's limited understanding of eSports poses significant challenges to its growth. The occasional banning of globally popular games further impedes the development of the industry, signaling a lack of government support for the sector. These bans have been a major barrier, restricting the competitiveness and global reach of Bangladeshi players.

Additionally, eSports is notably inclusive. Our findings reveal that eSports is not gender-biased, with players of all genders actively participating, reflecting the inclusive and diverse nature of the community. This inclusivity is crucial for the continued expansion of the eSports ecosystem.

Lastly, we explore the evolving perception of eSports as a viable career in Bangladesh. The shift from skepticism to gradual societal acceptance is largely driven by the increasing success of players on national and international stages, as well as the recognition of eSports as a legitimate career by families and educational institutions. This changing perception is important for broadening the reach of eSports as a professional pathway.

Our research findings not only contribute to a nuanced understanding of the local eSports scene but also hold broader implications for the HCI and ICT4D communities. The insights from this study enrich the ICTD and HCI communities by exploring how technology can drive non-traditional career paths and inclusivity in digital spaces. These findings will aid future research into the intersection of technology, social inclusion, and economic potential in eSports, providing a foundation for policymakers, researchers, and practitioners focused on driving socio-economic development through digital platforms.

5.1 Factors Contributing to the Growing Popularity of eSports

Our study reveals a notable paradigm shift in perceptions, with 74.8% of respondents recognizing eSports as a viable and respectable career choice. This transformation can be framed through the lens of behavioral theory, particularly Ajzen's Theory of Planned Behavior (TPB), which suggests that individuals' attitudes toward a behavior, along with subjective norms and perceived behavioral control, influence their intentions to engage in that behavior [1].

As respondents increasingly view eSports as legitimate, this shift in attitude could enhance their intention to pursue it as a career, aligning with Reitman et al.'s call for a broader understanding of eSports beyond traditional gameplay analysis and emphasizing the importance of interdisciplinary collaboration and accessibility [28]. This recognition of eSports as a legitimate career path reflects a shift in societal norms, further solidifying its place in professional domains.

Jenny et al. contribute valuable insights by advocating for formal recognition of eSports as an intercollegiate athletic sport, which can award scholarships in higher education [13]. In our study, 68.5% of respondents expressed a desire for greater educational recognition and formalization of eSports in academic institutions. This aligns with TPB's concept of perceived behavioral control—if educational institutions provide formal support and clear career pathways, individuals will feel more capable of pursuing eSports as a viable career option. Institutional support could foster structured career pathways, providing students the resources and opportunities to hone their eSports skills.

However, despite the positive shift in attitudes, concerns about the financial stability of eSports careers remain. Approximately 45.2% of respondents expressed reservations about the long-term financial sustainability of pursuing eSports professionally. These concerns resonate with Nagorsky et al.'s research, which emphasizes the need for a performance model grounded in game research and sports science, identifying competence profiles and training patterns that could help stabilize and professionalize the industry [22]. Economic considerations directly affect the perceived behavioral control aspect of TPB—if individuals do not feel financially secure in the profession, their intentions to pursue it may wane.

Interestingly, 53.7% of respondents expressed a desire to see greater integration of eSports with traditional career paths. This reflects the need for broader societal acceptance and practical avenues for eSports professionals to navigate multiple career options, aligning with Scholz et al.'s exploration of the eSports industry within the context of media management [32]. Integrating eSports with conventional careers not only increases the perceived legitimacy of eSports but also offers players diverse opportunities, thus fostering a more sustainable and versatile career trajectory for future professionals. This integration also touches upon subjective norms within TPB, as greater societal acceptance of eSports would enhance the perceived value of this career choice.

5.2 eSports as a Career Choice in Bangladesh

Our study reveals a notable paradigm shift in perceptions, with 74.8% of respondents acknowledging eSports as a viable and respectable career choice. This attitudinal transformation echoes the sentiments expressed by Reitman et al., who advocate for a comprehensive understanding of eSports beyond traditional gameplay analysis, emphasizing interdisciplinary collaboration and improved accessibility [28]. Recognizing eSports as a legitimate career underscores the evolving societal perspective towards this burgeoning industry.

Jenny et al. contribute valuable insights by delving into the classification of eSports in higher education, advocating for formal recognition as a scholarship-awarding intercollegiate athletic

sport [13]. In our study, 68.5% of respondents expressed a desire for increased educational recognition and formalization of eSports in academic institutions. This highlights the growing importance of eSports in educational contexts and the need for institutional support to nurture eSports talent and provide structured career pathways. While there is a positive shift in perceptions, concerns about the economic stability of eSports careers persist among respondents. Approximately 45.2% of participants expressed concerns about the long-term financial sustainability of pursuing eSports professionally. This mirrors the concerns raised by Nagorsky et al., who propose a performance model grounded in game research and sports science, revealing distinctive competence profiles and training patterns across genres [22]. Addressing these economic considerations is crucial for attracting and retaining talent within the eSports domain.

Government support, or lack thereof, plays a critical role in this discussion. In Bangladesh, the lack of governmental understanding of the eSports industry and frequent bans on globally popular games have stifled growth and potential career development for players. Without a supportive regulatory environment, aspiring professionals face hurdles in gaining the recognition and opportunities needed to pursue eSports as a long-term career. Interestingly, 53.7% of respondents desire greater integration of eSports with traditional career paths. This aligns with the observations made by Scholz et al., providing a comprehensive introductory overview of the eSports industry within the context of media management [32]. Integrating eSports with conventional career trajectories is seen as a crucial step in mainstreaming eSports as a legitimate and versatile career choice, bridging the gap between passion and practicality.

Furthermore, eSports stands out for its inclusivity, offering equal opportunities for all genders. This has helped foster a diverse and vibrant community that reflects modern digital career opportunities.

5.3 Economic Viability of eSports in Bangladesh

The economic landscape of eSports in Bangladesh is undergoing a transformative shift, with 81.5% of respondents recognizing eSports as a source of emerging job opportunities. This sentiment echoes the comprehensive analysis by Johnson et al., where various stakeholders' roles in the eSports industry are scrutinized, emphasizing financial gains and the emergence of new career prospects [14]. The growing acknowledgment of eSports as a viable career choice underscores its potential to contribute significantly to the country's job market.

Our findings further reveal that 62.4% of participants affirm the increasing presence of sponsorship and investment in the Bangladeshi eSports sector. This aligns with Newman et al.'s use of narrative economics to dissect private investment growth in North American eSports teams, highlighting the impact of public narratives on economic behaviors [23]. Understanding these sponsorship and investment trends becomes crucial for mapping the economic trajectory of eSports in Bangladesh.

However, despite these positive indicators, concerns over financial sustainability persist within the eSports community. Approximately 32.1% of respondents express apprehensions about the long-term financial sustainability of eSports careers in Bangladesh. This

mirrors the cautionary notes struck by Hamari et al., who conducted a comprehensive study on eSports viewership, uncovering motivations such as escapism and the allure of novelty [10]. Addressing these concerns is pivotal for ensuring eSports's economic stability and attractiveness as a viable career option.

A noteworthy insight from our study is the existence of regional disparities in economic opportunities within the eSports ecosystem. Participants from urban centers report more favorable economic prospects than their rural counterparts. This regional variation aligns with the findings of Lohman et al., who address eSports as a commercial activity and propose strategies for development in different regions [18]. Recognizing and mitigating these regional disparities is essential for fostering inclusive economic growth within the Bangladeshi eSports industry.

Government policies, or the lack thereof, further complicate the financial viability of eSports. The Bangladeshi government's limited understanding of eSports and their occasional bans on globally popular games hinder local growth and discourage private investments. A supportive regulatory framework is crucial for unlocking the full potential of eSports as a sustainable industry.

6 Limitations and Future Work

While our study offers valuable insights into Bangladesh's eSports landscape, there are several areas for future exploration. Using snowball sampling connected us with key industry members, but future research could employ stratified sampling to include underrepresented voices. Our focus on urban areas like Dhaka provided detailed insights, but expanding to rural regions could reveal different dynamics shaped by access to technology and traditional sports preferences.

Though digital platforms enabled rich data collection, future studies could incorporate more diverse methods, such as conducting research in underserved areas. Additionally, a longitudinal approach could capture the evolving nature of the eSports industry. Finally, including peer reviews and diversifying the research team could further minimize biases and strengthen future findings.

These advancements would enrich the understanding of eSports in Bangladesh and beyond, offering a broader perspective on its growth and impact.

7 Conclusion

In summary, the evolution of eSports in Bangladesh encapsulates a notable transition from casual gaming to a recognized and promising professional trajectory. Central to this transformation is the driving force of passion, motivating individuals to surmount societal skepticism and financial challenges in pursuit of their eSports aspirations. Despite encountering obstacles, the shifting attitudes toward eSports are palpable, bolstered by local success stories and increasing investments in the industry. This shift not only signifies a cultural transformation but also fosters a sense of community and solidarity among the younger generation. The study underscores the imperative for comprehensive support mechanisms, encompassing official acknowledgment, educational initiatives, augmented financial resources, and the facilitation of local tournaments, to cultivate a thriving eSports ecosystem in Bangladesh. By embracing and nurturing professional eSports, Bangladesh has the potential to

establish a flourishing cultural and economic paradigm that reaps benefits for individuals and the nation at large.

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